United States Patent	12397222
Kind Code	B1
Date of Patent	August 26, 2025
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Portable table stadium system

Abstract

Described are various embodiments of Portable Table Stadium System. In one embodiment, the system comprises one or more net assemblies, each net assembly comprising: a first goal post and a second goal post, each goal post configured to be removably secured to a table; a net coupled at a first end thereof to the first goal post, and at a second end thereof to a second goal post and extending therebetween. At least one support post per net assembly is disposed and secured to the table to engage with the net to provide vertical support thereto and to define at least in part an enclosed space on said table. Two goal posts proximate to one another are used to define a goal area. Some embodiments may include one or more accessories such as one or more bowling pins, obstacles and a ball.

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Appl. No.: **19/181986**

Filed: **April 17, 2025**

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: **A63D3/00** (20060101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC **A63D3/00** (20130101);

Field of Classification Search

CPC: A63D (3/00); A63F (7/00); A63F (7/0005); A63F (7/17); A63F (7/0017); A63F (7/0023); A63F (7/0616); A63F (7/07); A63F (2007/0011)

USPC: 273/108; 273/108.1; 273/108.5; 273/108.52; 273/108.54; 273/118R; 273/123R; 273/127R; 273/127B

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Background/Summary

FIELD OF THE DISCLOSURE

(1) The present disclosure relates to portable net assemblies, and, in particular, to a portable table netting stadium system.

BACKGROUND

(2) Extensible nets are typically used for playing games such as ping pong, also known as table tennis nets. They are designed to be easily adjustable and portable. These nets can be attached to various types of tables, allowing you to set up a game almost anywhere.

(3) This background information is provided to reveal information believed by the applicant to be of possible relevance. No admission is necessarily intended, nor should be construed, that any of the preceding information constitutes prior art or forms part of the general common knowledge in the relevant art.

SUMMARY

(4) The following presents a simplified summary of the general inventive concept(s) described herein to provide a basic understanding of some aspects of the disclosure. This summary is not an extensive overview of the disclosure. It is not intended to restrict key or critical elements of embodiments of the disclosure or to delineate their scope beyond that which is explicitly or implicitly described by the following description and claims.

(5) A need exists for a portable table stadium system that advantageously provides the ability to define an enclosed gaming area on tables of any shape and size, with one or more goal areas.

(6) In accordance with a first aspect, there is provided a portable stadium system comprising: one or more net assemblies, each net assembly comprising: a first goal post and a second goal post, each goal post configured to be removably secured to a table; a net coupled at a first end thereof to said first goal post, and at a second end thereof to a second goal post and extending therebetween; and at least one support post per net assembly, each support post configured to be removably secured to said table and disposed as to engage with the net of one of said one or more net assemblies to provide vertical support thereto and to define at least in part an enclosed space on said table.

(7) In some embodiments, at least one of said first goal post or second goal post comprises a

tensioning mechanism configured to vary a length of said net therebetween.
(8) In some embodiments, said tensioning mechanism comprises a reel for coiling said net therearound, the reel coupled to a tensioning wheel.
(9) In some embodiments, at least of said first goal post or second goal post is removably attached to said net.
(10) In some embodiments, each support post comprises a substantially elongated body comprising a plurality of protrusions extending laterally therefrom for engaging with one or more holes in said net.
(11) In some embodiments, said substantially elongated body of said support post is configured to be rotatable around an axis defined by a length thereof.
(12) In some embodiments, said support post comprises a clamping portion and wherein said substantially elongated body is offset with respect to said clamping portion so as to be above a surface of said table upon the support post being removably secured.
(13) In some embodiments, the system further comprises two or more net assemblies; wherein each net assembly of said two or more net assemblies has one goal post of said first or second goal post disposed proximate another goal post of said first or second goal post of another net assembly of said two or more net assemblies, thereby defining a goal area therebetween.
(14) In some embodiments, the system comprises three or more net assemblies, thereby defining correspondingly three or more goal areas.
(15) In some embodiments, the system comprises a single net assembly, thereby defining correspondingly a single goal area.
(16) In some embodiments, the system further comprises: a cross-bar having a substantially elongated body, and configured to be removably coupled at a first end thereof to an upper portion said one goal post and at a second end thereof to an upper portion of said another goal post.
(17) In some embodiments, the cross-bar is extensible.
(18) In some embodiments, the cross-bar comprises a scoring tracker.
(19) In some embodiments, the cross-bar further comprises a rigid frame defining a goal volume; and a stretchable goal net coupled to said rigid frame enclosing said goal volume.
(20) In some embodiments, the system further comprises: one or more bowling pin accessories; and at least one obstacle accessory.
(21) In some embodiments, at least one of said one or more bowling pin accessories is configured to have a resistance to being knocked down upon being impacted modified.
(22) In some embodiments, said resistance to being knocked down is changed by attaching a support disk at the bottom thereof.
(23) In some embodiments, the at least one of said one or more bowling pin accessories comprises an internal cavity, wherein said resistance to being knocked down is modified by filing said cavity with a material.
(24) In some embodiments, the at least one obstacle accessory is substantially cylindrically shaped and comprises a concave top surface. Other aspects, features and/or advantages will become more apparent upon reading of the following non-restrictive description of specific embodiments thereof, given by way of example only with reference to the accompanying drawings.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS
(1) Several embodiments of the present disclosure will be provided, by way of examples only, with reference to the appended drawings, wherein:
(2) FIG. **1** is a perspective view of a portable table stadium system, in accordance with one embodiment;

(3) FIG. **2**A and FIG. **2**B are perspective views of a goal post of the portable stadium system of FIG. **1**, in accordance with one embodiment;
(4) FIG. **3**A and FIG. **3**B are front views of a net assembly comprising a pair of goal posts having a net extended at different lengths, in accordance with one embodiment.
(5) FIG. **3**C is a front view of a net assembly comprising a goal post permanently affixed to the net, in accordance with one embodiment;
(6) FIG. **3**D is a front view of a net assembly comprising a goal post having a slot to removably attach an end of the net thereto, in accordance with one embodiment;
(7) FIGS. **4**A-**4**D are different views of a cross-bar in various configurations, in accordance with one embodiment;
(8) FIG. **5**A and FIG. **5**B are perspective views of a support post, in accordance with one embodiment;
(9) FIG. **6**A and FIG. **6**B are side views illustrating different clamping mechanisms for the support posts, in accordance with one embodiment;
(10) FIGS. **7**A-**7**D are top views of the portable stadium system comprising two net assemblies installed on a square (FIG. **7**A), rectangular (FIG. **7**B), circular (FIG. **7**C) and oval (FIG. **7**D) table, in accordance with one embodiment;
(11) FIG. **8** is a top view of the portable stadium system in a configuration comprising four net assemblies, in accordance with one embodiment;
(12) FIG. **9** is a top view of the portable stadium system in a configuration comprising a single net assembly, in accordance with one embodiment;
(13) FIG. **10** and FIG. **11** are front views of a bowling pin, in accordance with different embodiments; and
(14) FIG. **12** is top perspective view of an obstacle accessory, in accordance with one embodiment.
(15) Elements in the several drawings are illustrated for simplicity and clarity and have not necessarily been drawn to scale. For example, the dimensions of some of the elements in the figures may be emphasized relative to other elements for facilitating understanding of the various presently disclosed embodiments. Also, common, but well-understood elements that are useful or necessary in commercially feasible embodiments are often not depicted in order to facilitate a less obstructed view of these various embodiments of the present disclosure.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(16) Various implementations and aspects of the specification will be described with reference to details discussed below. The following description and drawings are illustrative of the specification and are not to be construed as limiting the specification. Numerous specific details are described to provide a thorough understanding of various implementations of the present specification. However, in certain instances, well-known or conventional details are not described in order to provide a concise discussion of implementations of the present specification.
(17) Furthermore, numerous specific details are set forth in order to provide a thorough understanding of the implementations described herein. However, it will be understood by those skilled in the relevant arts that the implementations described herein may be practiced without these specific details. In other instances, well-known methods, procedures and components have not been described in detail so as not to obscure the implementations described herein.
(18) In this specification, elements may be described as “configured to” perform one or more functions or “configured for” such functions. In general, an element that is configured to perform or configured for performing a function is enabled to perform the function, or is suitable for performing the function, or is adapted to perform the function, or is operable to perform the function, or is otherwise capable of performing the function.
(19) When introducing elements of aspects of the disclosure or the examples thereof, the articles “a,” “an,” “the,” and “said” are intended to mean that there are one or more of the elements. The terms “comprising,” “including,” and “having” are intended to be inclusive and mean that there

may be additional elements other than the listed elements. The term “exemplary” is intended to mean “an example of.” The phrase “one or more of the following: A, B, and C” means “at least one of A and/or at least one of B and/or at least one of C.”

(20) The system and method of the present disclosure provide examples, in accordance with different embodiments, of a portable stadium system that provides one or more net assemblies and support posts that allows to turn any table surface into an enclosed gaming area or surface. The system comprises one or more net assemblies, each comprising a pair of goal posts having an extensible net therebetween, that are deployed along the perimeter of any table. Two or more pairs of such goal posts can be affixed to any table to form correspondingly two or more open goal areas therebetween. The support poles are similarly affixed to the table and provide vertical support for the extended nets. This provides an efficient means of deploying the nets along the perimeter of the table and to closely circumscribe the play area within the table surface. This advantageously allows the extended nets to be deployed on any type of table, including many shapes and sizes, as will be shown below.

(21) FIG. **1** shows an exemplary non-limiting embodiment of the portable table stadium system **102** during play. This example uses only two pairs of goal posts **104***a* and **104***b*, each pair having an extensible net (**106***a* or **106***b*) deployed therebetween For added clarity, each pair of goal posts and the extensible net therebetween are labeled with a same letter. Therefore, the pair of goal posts **104***a* comprise an extensible net **106***a* therebetween, while the second pair of goal posts **104***b* comprise a corresponding extensible net **106***b* therebetween. In this example, each net post in a same pair are removably affixed to an opposite end of the table **108**. For a given end, the combination of a goal post **104***a* from the first pair and a goal post **104***b* from the second pair defines a goal area **110** therebetween. To vertically support the extensible nets **106***a* and **106***b* over the length of the table, one or more support posts **112** are provided. The number of support posts **112** used depends on the size and shape of the table. For a rectangular table, such as the one illustrated in FIG. **1**, four support posts **112** are enough to fully circumscribe the edges of the table and define a play area **114**. Additional examples using additional support posts, and additional goal posts as well, will be discussed below.

(22) Also included in this example are extensible goal cross-bars **116** that can be installed over the top portion of the goal posts **104***a* and **104***b*. The desired length of each goal cross-bar **116** can be adjusted to accommodate the width of the goal area **110**, and further provides support for an attachable goal net **118** that prevents objects from falling off the table surface during play.

(23) It will be appreciated by the person skilled in the art that the play area created on the table surface with the goal posts and support posts of system **102** can be used to play a plurality of different games, without exception. In some embodiments, additional play accessories may also be included with the goal posts and support posts. FIG. **1** illustrates such a non-limiting example where the system further comprises accessories like a ball **120**, a plurality of bowling pins **122**, and at least one heavy obstacle **124**. The goal of the game is to project the ball **120** (via a finger flick or similar) over the table surface in the direction of the opposing team's goal area. Bowling pins **122** represent “players” that provide obstacles that can be bounced from and/or knocked over with the ball (removing them from the play surface), while the obstacle **124** is the “referee” located in the middle. The obstacle **124** is heavy and stable enough so as to not be knocked over when impacted with the ball, and in this example prevents the players from shooting the ball in a straight line across the play area. It will be appreciated that a different number of bowling pins **122** and obstacles **124**, and different configurations thereof, can be used than those illustrated, without limitation. In addition, the bowling pins **122** can include variably weighted bowling pins.

(24) FIG. **2**A shows an exemplary goal post **202**, in accordance with one embodiment. In this example, goal post **202** (of a pair of goal posts of the net assembly) comprises a substantially elongated body **204** comprising a slot **206** along the length thereof which allows the extensible net to be extended therefrom. In this example, the goal post **202** comprises, as an example only, a push

down and spring tension foot style clamp. This is incorporated by having the elongated body **204** comprising at a lower end thereof an flat lower portion **208**, which is designed to lay over the table surface, while a movable lower clamp member **210** is adjusted to securely attach or secure the goal post to the table. A release button **212** is provided to easily detach the goal post from the table. Other embodiments may use different clamp designs or attachment means known in the art, without limitation. A lip **214** is also provided to support a goal cross-bar.

(25) In some embodiments, a netting tensioning mechanism may be provided as well. For example, FIG. **2**B shows a partial see-through view of the elongated body comprising therein a goal post may comprise a reel **216** coupled to an end of the net, allowing the net to be extended or coiled to increase tension. The reel **216** may be coupled with a ratcheting mechanism comprising a pawl and a spring (not shown) that allow for ratcheting of the perimeter netting when turning a tensioning wheel or crank **218**. A tension release button **220** is provided to release the pawl and decrease tension. It will be appreciated that different ratcheting mechanisms or configurations may be used, without limitation. In some embodiments only one of the two goal posts in a same pair may comprise the tensioning mechanism. In those embodiments, the reel **216** in one of the goal posts is not connected to a ratcheting mechanism, but instead allowed to turn freely. A non-tensionable goal post will also not require the tensioning wheel or release button.

(26) FIG. **3**A and FIG. **3**B show examples of how the net **302** can be extended between the pairs of goal posts **202**. The height of the goal posts **202** and the net **302** should be large enough to avoid play accessories from falling off the table, while the length of the net **302** should be long enough to accommodate half the perimeter of a common dinner table or the like. It will be appreciated that different goal posts with different dimensions may be provided, to accommodate different needs/requirements.

(27) FIG. **3**C and FIG. **3**D show two exemplary embodiments where only one of the two goal posts comprises a tensioning mechanism. In the example of FIG. **3**C, the net **302** is permanently secured to the goal post **304**. Any means known in the art to secure the net to the goal post may be considered, without exception. A top portion **306** is similarly shaped to the tensioning wheel **218** so as to provide engagement with the goal cross-bar. In the example of FIG. **3**D, the net assembly comprises a goal post **308** having a body **310** comprising a slot **312** along the length thereof for receiving an elongated member **314** shaped and configured to be slidingly secured therein. In this example, the slot **312** may be similar to the one illustrated in FIG. **3**A but would extend all the way to the top. It will be appreciated that other types of attachment mechanisms may be considered as well.

(28) The enclose the upper portion of the goal area, a cross-bar is provided that can be attached to the goal posts therebetween. This cross-bar can have a fixed pre-determined length, or can in some examples be extensible. FIGS. **4**A-**4**D provide different views of an extensible goal cross-bar **402**, in accordance with one embodiment. FIG. **4**A and FIG. **4**B show an exemplary C-shaped goal cross-bar **402** comprising a first portion **404** and a second portion **406** slidingly coupled to one another. This exemplary goal cross-bar **402** is configured to be extensible to accommodate different goal area widths. In this non-limiting example, a plurality of holes **408** on the first portion **404** are provided that can be engaged with a rounded spring-loaded protrusion **410** on the second portion **406**. This allows the length of the goal cross-bar **402** to be adjusted and locked. Pressing the spring-loaded protrusion **502** unlocks the mechanism and the length may be changed once more. The number and size of the holes **408** is only exemplary and different configurations may be used instead. In addition, a scoring tracker **412** is also provided to help track score for each team. In this example the scoring tracker **412** comprises a slider **414** but other embodiments may use any other means known in the art, including electronic displays.

(29) FIG. **4**C illustrates how the goal cross-bar **402** may be slidingly engaged on the top of two goal posts **202***a* and **202***b* (from different pairs) to rest on a lip portion **214** thereof. Two holes **416** are sized so as to be engageable over the tensioning wheels **218** (if present) but small enough so the

goal cross-bar **402** can rest on the lips **214** of the goal posts.

(30) FIG. **4**D shows an exemplary extensible net **418** that can be attached to the goal cross-bar **402**. The netting of the extensible net **418** should be made of resilient and elastic threads to stretch when the cross-bar is elongated. A rigid frame **420** defining a goal volume may also be provided to ensure that the extensible net **418** enclosing the volume retains its shape and prevents a ball or other object from falling off the table when entering the goal area.

(31) FIG. **5**A and FIG. **5**B provide views of a support post **504**, in accordance with one embodiment. In this example, the support post comprises a substantially elongated body **506** that is higher than the height of the perimeter netting. A plurality of protrusions **502** are disposed along the length of the body **506**. These are sized, shaped and disposed so as to easily engage the perimeter netting, thereby providing vertical support. The protrusions **502** may include bumps and/or spikes as well. Different shapes may be used simultaneously on a same support post. This specific example includes four linear arrays of protrusions along opposing sides.

(32) The support posts further comprises an attachment mechanism. In this example, the support post **504** comprises a clamp mechanism comprising a fixed upper clamp portion **508**, which is coupled to a moveable lower clamp portion **510**. Similarly to the goal posts discussed above, the movable lower clamp portion **510** comprises a release button **512** which provide a quick way to detach the support post from the table. Other embodiments may use different clamping or attachment mechanism, without limitation. Moreover, the body **506** is offset **514** forward with respect with the clamp so that the support post is located above the table surface when attached, which avoids creating gaps in which the ball or other objects might fall.

(33) In some embodiments, as shown in FIG. **5**B, instead of being coupled to the upper clamp portion **508** directly, the elongated body **506** of the support post **504** may be rotatably mounted on a fixed elongated member **516**. This allows the body **506** of the support post **504** to freely roll or rotate around an axis defined by its length, which avoids the perimeter netting from getting caught in the protrusion when tension is adjusted (the body **504** simply rolls and allows the netting to move).

(34) FIG. **6**A and FIG. **6**B show examples of clamping mechanisms that can be used with the goal posts and/or support posts, in accordance with two embodiments. FIG. **6**A comprises an adjustable member **602** coupled to a bar **604** with notches. The member **602** comprises a ratchetting mechanism coupled to a release lever **606**. A tightening screw **608** with a rubber-like tip is engaged within the member **602** and can be extended to secure the clamp on a table. FIG. **6**B shows a quick release design comprising a well-known Irwin style clamp having a ratcheted movable member **610** coupled to a grip **612** that ratchets the member **610** upon the grip being engaged. Also illustrated in FIG. **6**A is the forward offset **614** of the substantially elongated member **616** of the support post with respect to the clamp position, ensuring that the support post is always above the table surface so as to not create gaps in the enclosure. It will be appreciated that the illustrated exemplary clamping mechanisms of FIGS. **6**A and **6**B may be used on the goal posts as well, without limitation.

(35) FIGS. **7**A-**7**D provide examples illustrating how the portable table stadium netting system can be efficiently configured to accommodate different table sizes and shapes. All these examples use the same two pairs of goal posts **702***a* and **702***b*, each pair coupled to the extended nets **704***a* and **704***b*. FIG. **7**A and FIG. **7**B show how square (**706**) and rectangular (**708**) tables, respectively, may be accommodated with four support posts **710**, while FIG. **7**C and FIG. **7**D show how round (**712**) and oval (**714**) tables, respectively, can be accommodated with six support posts **710**. It will be appreciated that additional support posts may further be used to circumscribe more complex table shapes. In these examples, the goal cross-bar was omitted for added clarity.

(36) While most of the example have shown two net assemblies, any number of net assemblies may be used to define the play area. FIG. **8** provides an example of a portable table stadium system **802** comprising more than two net assemblies, in accordance with one embodiment. In this example,

four net assemblies (comprising four pairs of goal posts **804***a*, **804***b*, **804***c* and **804***d*) are used to create four goal areas (**806**, **808**, **810**, and **812**) over a square table surface **814**. Four support posts **816** are used to each support a different net (**818***a*, **818***b*, **818***c* and **818***d*). It will be appreciated that any number of pairs of goal posts may be used to create correspondingly two or more goal areas, without limitation.
(37) In some embodiments, a single net assembly may be used. FIG. **9** provides such an exemplary embodiment of a portable table stadium system **902** comprising a single net assembly installed on a square table **904**. The net assembly comprises two goal posts **906***a* defining a single goal area **908**, and the net **910***a* therebetween is supported by at least four support posts **912**.
(38) FIG. **10** shows an example of a bowling pin accessory **1002**, in accordance with one embodiment. In this example, the bowling pin accessory **1002** comprises a body **1004** made of a rigid and light material. The bowling pins are meant to be knocked over so should not be too heavy. In this example, the body **1004** is removably attached to a support disk **1006** which increases the pin's resistance to being knocked over. Different sizes of the support disk **1006** may be used, to provide various levels of resistance.
(39) FIG. **11** illustrates another embodiment of a bowling pin **1102**. In this example, the bowling pin's body **1104** comprises an internal cavity **1106** that can be filled with various amounts of liquid or other material (such as sand or the like), thereby increasing its resistance to being knocked over.
(40) FIG. **12** shows an exemplary obstacle accessory **1202**, in accordance with one embodiment. In this example, the obstacle comprises a substantially cylindrical body **1204** as an example only, and other shapes may be considered as well. The obstacle accessory **1202** should be made of a rigid material and weight enough so as to not being knocked over or displaced when impacted by a ball (such as ball **120** in FIG. **1**). However, the obstacle accessory **1202** should not weigh too much so as to be easily moved or displaced by the users on the table surface. In this example of FIG. **1**, it obstructs shots and acts as a deterrent for direct shots from long distances and encourages angles and net shots to be taken to bounce the ball around the stadium. In some embodiments, the obstacle accessory comprises a concave surface **1206** on its top end, which can be used to hold the ball when not in use.
(41) While the present disclosure describes various embodiments for illustrative purposes, such description is not intended to be limited to such embodiments. On the contrary, the applicant's teachings described and illustrated herein encompass various alternatives, modifications, and equivalents, without departing from the embodiments, the general scope of which is defined in the appended claims. Information as herein shown and described in detail is fully capable of attaining the above-described object of the present disclosure, the presently preferred embodiment of the present disclosure, and is, thus, representative of the subject matter which is broadly contemplated by the present disclosure.

Claims

1. A portable stadium system comprising: one or more net assemblies, each net assembly comprising: a first goal post and a second goal post, each goal post configured to be removably secured to a table; a net coupled at a first end thereof to said first goal post, and at a second end thereof to a second goal post and extending therebetween; and at least one support post per net assembly, each support post configured to be removably secured to said table and disposed as to engage with the net of one of said one or more net assemblies to provide vertical support thereto and to define at least in part an enclosed space on said table; and wherein each support post comprises a substantially elongated body comprising a plurality of protrusions extending laterally therefrom for engaging with one or more holes in said net.
2. The portable stadium system of claim 1, wherein at least one of said first goal post or second goal post comprises a tensioning mechanism configured to vary a length of said net therebetween.

3. The portable stadium system of claim 2, wherein said tensioning mechanism comprises a reel for coiling said net therearound, the reel coupled to a tensioning wheel.
4. The portable stadium system of claim 2, wherein at least of said first goal post or second goal post is removably attached to said net.
5. The portable stadium system of claim 1, wherein said substantially elongated body of said support post is configured to be rotatable around an axis defined by a length thereof.
6. The portable stadium system of claim 1, wherein said support post comprises a clamping portion and wherein said substantially elongated body is offset with respect to said clamping portion so as to be above a surface of said table upon the support post being removably secured.
7. The portable stadium system of claim 1, comprising two or more net assemblies; and wherein each net assembly of said two or more net assemblies has one goal post of said first or second goal post disposed proximate another goal post of said first or second goal post of another net assembly of said two or more net assemblies, thereby defining a goal area therebetween.
8. The portable stadium system of claim 7, comprising three or more net assemblies, thereby defining correspondingly three or more goal areas.
9. The portable stadium system of claim 7, further comprising: a cross-bar having a substantially elongated body, and configured to be removably coupled at a first end thereof to an upper portion said one goal post and at a second end thereof to an upper portion of said another goal post.
10. The portable stadium system of claim 9, wherein the cross-bar is extensible.
11. The portable stadium system of claim 9, wherein the cross-bar comprises a scoring tracker.
12. The portable stadium system of claim 9, further comprising: a rigid frame attachable to the cross-bar and defining a goal volume; and a stretchable goal net coupled to said cross-bar and rigid frame enclosing said goal volume.
13. The portable stadium system of claim 1, comprising a single net assembly, thereby defining correspondingly a single goal area between said first goal post and said second goal post.
14. The portable stadium system of claim 1, further comprising: one or more bowling pin accessories; and at least one obstacle accessory.
15. The portable stadium system of claim 14, wherein at least one of said one or more bowling pin accessories is configured to have a resistance to being knocked down upon being impacted modified.
16. The portable of claim 15, wherein said resistance to being knocked down is changed by attaching a support disk at the bottom thereof.
17. The portable of claim 14, wherein said at least one of said one or more bowling pin accessories comprises an internal cavity, wherein said resistance to being knocked down is modified by filing said cavity with a material.
18. The portable of claim 14, wherein said at least one obstacle accessory is substantially cylindrically shaped and comprises a concave top surface.